fourteen-year-old that his grandmother, the then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, had been brutally assassinated by her own security men, to answering a phone call seven years later that brought news of his father's brutal death. One can imagine how scarred one would be. But it is truly remarkable how he bears no malice and carries no anger. His losses have only made him more empathetic. By the time he finished his speech, the stage was full of moist eyes. I remember standing right behind his sister, Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi, who was the first to step forward to hug him. There was something about that time in Kashmir, something in him when he turned around, something in his eyes and his smile—it almost felt like, in that moment, he was touched by an unknown but miraculous, powerful force. It was an energy that cannot be put into words.

The Bharat Jodo Yatra was a ray of unwavering hope in a world full of broken dreams. For me it was the living, walking equivalence of joy. Joy that doesn't need to be heralded by a ceremony or a grand gesture or a roomful of roses. Joy that doesn't need perfection, that enters our imperfect lives and fills our fault lines, that makes us smile effortlessly. Joy that chooses us, and we embrace it right back.

The Bharat Jodo Yatra chose all of us and entered our imperfections, those crevices of hate, to make us believe in the power of love, the power of that *mohabbat ki dukaan* in *nafrat ka bazaar*, the power of 'we the people'. It made us better versions of ourselves.